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Toni Kroos: Bayern Munich's Best Hope

By Stefan Bienkowski May 17, 2012 12:01 am

The UEFA Champions League final Saturday between Chelsea and Bayern Munich will be the ninth appearance for the German team as it hopes to pick up its fifth European title — in its own stadium, Allianz Arena. All that stands between the Bavarian team and European triumph is a peculiar opponent in Chelsea. Bayern must be wary.

Like a telepathic infant swinging for the piñata with deathly precision, Chelsea has continued to dumbfound with its ability to overcome seemingly impossible tasks. The most notable of these minor miracles was its astounding ability to defeat mighty Barcelona over two legs with an aging squad and an interim manager in Roberto Di Matteo — appointed as a care taker in early March after the dismissal of Andre Villas Boas.

Perhaps the most admirable segment of the two-part thriller that was the semifinal affair between the Blues and their Catalanian opponents, was Di Matteo's ability to turn Chelsea from overpaid has been's and lofty egos in to a hard working, defensive unit of modest underdogs. Within that ethos rested the ability to overcome Barcelona — the greatest attacking team in modern soccer -- and the key threat to Bayern Munich's chances of winning on Saturday.

For all Bayern's wealth in attacking option offered by Frank Ribéry, Arjen Robben and Mario Gomez, there is nothing that Barcelona had not already tried against Chelsea's unfathomable defense. If Bayern Coach Jupp Heynckes is to unlock the Chelsea backline it will have to come from the source of his team's success, the architect of its recent triumphs, and most importantly; somebody

who Chelsea will not be able to simply mark out of the game — the 22-year-old midfielder Toni Kroos.

As a local boy surrounded by international superstars, Kroos has been German soccer's worst-kept secret for a number of years, with the midfielder slowly but surely edging his way into the team since his return from a loan spell at Leverkusen in 2010. Carving a spot of his own in the Bayern Munich midfield and into the heart of Bavarian fan, the young starlet has been vital to Bayern's European success this season.

His sharp intuition and the ability to pass the ball at any speed, height or angle already sets him apart from his fellow midfielders at Bayern Munich, and a notable contender for future individual awards within Germany and across the continent.

The midfielder possesses a humility that underlines his entire game. Like Andrés Iniesta of Barcelona or Paul Scholes of Manchester United, he drifts through games on another level. The elegant harp strings to the thunderous brass of Ribéry, Robben and Gomez — noticeable when he needs to be, but invisible when it suits.

While Real Madrid prepared for Robben and Frank Ribéry, in the first leg of the semifinals — what they regarded as the Munich team's greatest threats — Heynckes simply altered his midfield with the inclusion of Bastian Schweinsteiger alongside Luis Gustavo. A defensive pairing with the intention of thwarting Madrid's midfield, but more importantly — a tactical move to allow Kroos the freedom to roam forward.

The manner in which the young German went on to command that first leg at Allianz Arena was not only an immaculate demonstration of his own talents as a player, but a live exhibition of perfectly synchronized skill. A faultless illustration of what the complete midfielder should be.

His ability to subdue and pester the midfield of Real Madrid — a team that scored 121 goals this season -- to the point where Xabi Alonso and Sami Khedira were forced to sit as far back as their own backline — was a testament to their new found respect for the youngster. His corner was the cross that reached Ribéry for the first goal. An assist to add to the six he previously recorded in the competition.

The second leg was no different. Despite the best efforts of the greatest tactician in the world, Jose Mourinho, Kroos continued to float past Madrid players and weave his intricate passes upon the backdrop of frustrated pursuers.

The finest compliment one could level at the young German is the manner in which Bayern struggle without him or if he is forced to play a different position. When asked to play defensive midfielder — as has been the case in numerous domestic games this season — Kroos's influence in the final third of the field is limited, which is when Bayern begins to struggle.

Like impatient children, Robben and Ribéry attack defenses without a moment's hesitation, throwing precision and apt timing out the window. The most common symptom of a Kroos-less Bayern attack is the situation where the forward players simply pass the ball around the opposition box, struggling to find inspiration or an opening toward goal. Their limitations are an acknowledgment to the manner in which they depend upon young Kroos to create that killer ball.

His ability to pick out a threatening through ball from deep or find space on the edge of the box will be vital to any success Bayern hope to find. On defense, Chelsea's double marking and intention to close that down Bayern's forward line will create traps and accidental lapses that the German team hopes Kroos will exploit. If Bayern Munich do beat Chelsea Saturday it may come from a Gomez header, a Robben shot, or even a volley from Schweinsteiger, but the one certainty that connects all these possibilities is the tactful contribution Kroos is likely to make.

On Saturday Kroos will walk in to Allianz Arena as the sole hope of a club he has been playing for since he was a child. Upon the biggest stage, against a formidable opponent, the world will watch as his team do everything within its power to win the Champions League trophy — regarded by some as the greatest prize in team sports.

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